

campaign of reprisal airstrikes. Initially, 49 sorties were flown by US and South Vietnamese pilots. Significantly, the targets for their attack included Viet Cong strongholds near the demilitarized zone (DMZ) on the border of the two countries, and also struck North Vietnamese military installations, hinting at the air war to come.

Following Viet Cong reprisals, US fighter-bombers, launched from US aircraft carriers in the Gulf of Tonkin, undertook further strikes against North Vietnamese and Viet Cong targets. On March 2, in a massive further commitment to the conflict, the United States launched Operation Rolling Thunder. This sustained bombing campaign was intended to drive North Vietnam out of the war entirely.

Landing at Da Nang

The escalation of the air war required more American military personnel on the ground in South Vietnam for security and support. On March 8, 1965, elements of the Ninth Marine Expeditionary Brigade landed near the city of Da Nang, where they were met on the beach by city officials and a welcoming crowd. Charged with securing American bases to free up South Vietnamese soldiers for combat operations, these Marines were the first official American combat troops in South Vietnam. By the end of the year, more than 180,000 American service personnel were stationed in bases throughout South Vietnam.